

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nonprofit and NGO English



Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Theory of change

02 Restricted grant funds

03 Output versus outcome

04 Field partner coordination

05 Safeguarding referral

06 Volunteer boundaries

07 Public messaging review

08 Board sustainability discussion

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Theory of change

A program team connects activities to intended outcomes.

Roles: Program manager / Evaluation lead

Program manager: Our plan lists workshops, but it doesn't explain how they lead to the outcome we promise.

Evaluation lead: Map the intended change, the assumptions, and the evidence connecting each step.

Program manager: Attendance would measure delivery, not whether participants can apply the skill.

Evaluation lead: Exactly. We need suitable outcome measures and a feasible way to collect them.

Program manager: I'll revise the program logic and identify assumptions we need to test.

Evaluation lead: I'll help align the evaluation questions with what the program can reasonably demonstrate.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Our plan lists workshops, but it doesn't explain how they lead to the outcome we promise." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Restricted grant funds

A team discusses an urgent unbudgeted expense.

Roles: Program director / Grants officer

Program director: We have grant funds left. Can we use them to cover the office repair?

Grants officer: We need to check the award restrictions and approved budget before committing the money.

Program director: The repair is urgent, but it wasn't part of the funded project.

Grants officer: Urgency doesn't change the restriction. We can examine other funding or ask about an authorized budget amendment.

Program director: I'll provide the cost and operational impact.

Grants officer: I'll review the options and document any required donor approval before spending.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We have grant funds left. Can we use them to cover the office repair?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Output versus outcome

A nonprofit prepares a donor update.

Roles: Monitoring officer / Development manager

Monitoring officer: We trained 240 participants. Can the report say 240 people improved their employment prospects?

Development manager: Only if our evidence supports that outcome. Attendance alone doesn't demonstrate it.

Monitoring officer: We have a follow-up survey, but only 80 people responded.

Development manager: Report the response rate and limitations. Don't present respondents as all participants.

Monitoring officer: I'll separate delivery figures from reported changes.

Development manager: Good. We can tell a useful story while accurately describing what was measured.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We trained 240 participants. Can the report say 240 people improved their employment prospects?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Field partner coordination

A field team prepares a distribution with a partner.

Roles: Field coordinator / Partner organization lead

Field coordinator: The delivery contains fewer kits than planned. How should we adjust tomorrow's distribution?

Partner organization lead: First verify the quantity and apply the agreed allocation criteria. We shouldn't make informal promises.

Field coordinator: I'll confirm stock and identify affected locations.

Partner organization lead: I'll consult the local team on communication and access considerations.

Field coordinator: We'll document the revised plan and explain the shortfall clearly.

Partner organization lead: Confirm responsibilities before dispatch so each team knows what it is delivering and reporting.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The delivery contains fewer kits than planned. How should we adjust tomorrow's distribution?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Safeguarding referral

A staff member raises a concern through the designated channel.

Roles: Program officer / Safeguarding focal point

Program officer: A volunteer reported a safeguarding concern. I recorded their words without trying to investigate it myself.

Safeguarding focal point: Thank you. Use the approved reporting route and limit information to those who need it.

Program officer: They asked whether we can guarantee complete confidentiality.

Safeguarding focal point: Explain the process accurately, including its limits. Don't promise something the organization cannot ensure.

Program officer: I'll pass the record through the secure channel now.

Safeguarding focal point: I'll coordinate the response under our safeguarding procedures and confirm appropriate next steps with you.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "A volunteer reported a safeguarding concern. I recorded their words without trying to investigate it myself." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Volunteer boundaries

A coordinator clarifies a volunteer's role.

Roles: Volunteer coordinator / Team supervisor

Volunteer coordinator: A volunteer has started giving participants advice beyond their assigned role.

Team supervisor: We should explain the boundary using the role description and examples, without dismissing their wish to help.

Volunteer coordinator: I'll arrange a conversation and ask what situations prompted it.

Team supervisor: Clarify which questions need referral to qualified staff and how to make that referral.

Volunteer coordinator: We'll provide a short practice scenario and check their understanding.

Team supervisor: I'll reinforce the same boundary during supervision and document any further support needed.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "A volunteer has started giving participants advice beyond their assigned role." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Public messaging review

A campaign team considers a dramatic claim.

Roles: Communications lead / Policy officer

Communications lead: The draft says our program ended homelessness in the district. The data don't support that.

Policy officer: We can describe the housing placements we supported and the period covered.

Communications lead: A partner wants to feature a participant's story and photograph too.

Policy officer: Check informed permission, the agreed use, and any protection concerns before publication.

Communications lead: I'll revise the claim and route the story through our review process.

Policy officer: I'll verify the evidence and make the limits clear without erasing the program's actual contribution.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The draft says our program ended homelessness in the district. The data don't support that." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Board sustainability discussion

A nonprofit board pack includes an optimistic funding assumption.

Roles: Executive director / Finance manager

Executive director: The budget assumes renewal of our largest grant. How much is confirmed?

Finance manager: The application is submitted, but the donor hasn't decided. The renewal is an assumption.

Executive director: Show a scenario without it and identify when we need a decision on commitments.

Finance manager: I'll distinguish restricted balances from funds available for general operations.

Executive director: Include the operational options and their effects on the mission.

Finance manager: I'll prepare the cash outlook and trigger dates so the board can act before resources become constrained.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The budget assumes renewal of our largest grant. How much is confirmed?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: name one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

SHARED CASE

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

SHARED CASE

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

SHARED CASE

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Field Operations and Partner Coordination

SHARED CASE

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

SHARED CASE

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Volunteer Management and Training

SHARED CASE

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

SHARED CASE

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Board Reporting and Sustainability

SHARED CASE

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Attendance is not lasting employment improvement

The lesson's program reports 200 workshop attendees but has not measured follow-up employment outcomes.

01 • Program manager: Two hundred people attended our workshops. The draft calls that proof of lasting employment improvement.

02 • Evaluation officer: Attendance is an output: it tells us what the program delivered, not what happened afterward.

03 • Program manager: Then an outcome would concern a change in participants' circumstances rather than simply their presence?

04 • Evaluation officer: Exactly. We haven't measured follow-up employment outcomes, so the lasting-improvement claim goes beyond our evidence.

05 • Program manager: How does the theory of change fit into this distinction for the board discussion?

06 • Evaluation officer: It explains how we expect activities to contribute to our mission. It doesn't prove that contribution occurred.

07 • Program manager: So we can explain the intended link between workshops and employment without claiming the link has been demonstrated.

08 • Evaluation officer: Yes. Keep the observed attendance figure and the intended outcome in separate sentences.

09 • Program manager: I'll revise the spoken update to report attendance and identify the missing follow-up information.

10 • Evaluation officer: Good. That recognizes delivered work while making clear what we still need to learn about outcomes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Food parcels and household stability

Separate fictional case: a community organization distributed 300 food parcels this month; no information on longer-term household stability has been collected.

01 • Community program lead: We distributed three hundred parcels. Can our presentation describe that as three hundred households becoming stable?

02 • Learning coordinator: No. Parcel distribution is an output, and the count doesn't establish either unique households or lasting stability.

03 • Community program lead: I see two gaps: recipients may repeat, and receiving a parcel doesn't itself measure the longer-term outcome.

04 • Learning coordinator: Correct. Our mission may include household stability, but we need an appropriate measure of that change.

05 • Community program lead: Could we explain the parcels as an immediate activity within our theory of change instead?

06 • Learning coordinator: Yes. Say how the activity is intended to help without claiming unmeasured results.

07 • Community program lead: I'll use parcels distributed as the label, rather than families transformed or another unsupported description.

08 • Learning coordinator: That will make the figure easier to interpret and avoid overstating what the program knows.

09 • Community program lead: Let's discuss what follow-up would be useful and proportionate before making another impact claim.

10 • Learning coordinator: Agreed. We'll distinguish the delivery record from any future evidence about participant outcomes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A mentoring match is the start, not the result

Separate fictional case: a youth mentoring project has made twenty matches; meetings and participant outcomes have not yet been tracked.

01 • Mentoring coordinator: Twenty mentoring matches are in place. Is that an outcome we can present to the donor?

02 • Program designer: It is a useful delivery milestone, but it doesn't show whether mentoring meetings happened or participants benefited.

03 • Mentoring coordinator: So the match is part of the activity pathway, and improvement would need separate evidence?

04 • Program designer: Exactly. The theory of change describes the expected steps between matching people and the intended benefit.

05 • Mentoring coordinator: Would saying the project created twenty successful mentoring relationships still overstate what we know?

06 • Program designer: Yes. We haven't tracked meetings or defined relationship success, so that label adds an unsupported conclusion.

07 • Mentoring coordinator: I'll say twenty matches were made and explain that engagement and outcomes remain to be assessed.

08 • Program designer: Good. We should choose follow-up questions that respect participants and fit the program's purpose.

09 • Mentoring coordinator: Then the donor update can celebrate the setup milestone without turning it into evidence of lasting change.

10 • Program designer: Precisely. Clear distinctions help us discuss progress honestly and identify the next learning need.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

Scenario 2 | Downloads recorded; use and outcomes unknown

A fictional nonprofit's budgeting guide has 500 downloads. The organization has no information on unique readers, use of the guide, or changed financial behavior. Explain the output and intended outcome without giving financial advice.

Role A: You are the program communications lead. Explain what the download count actually measures.

Role B: You are the learning officer. Ask how use and outcomes would differ from downloads.

Possible opening: Five hundred downloads show distribution activity, not five hundred confirmed changes in financial behavior.

Success checks

- Distinguish downloads, users, and outcomes.
- Explain the intended mission connection without claiming proof.
- Identify a proportionate follow-up question rather than invent a result.

Add a complication: A donor asks you to describe all downloads as people helped.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Check the award before moving funds

The lesson's team proposes moving grant money to another activity, but the award restrictions have not been checked.

01 • Program lead: We want to move some grant money to another activity. Could you clarify whether the award permits that?

02 • Grants manager: I need to check the award terms. We haven't established whether this is restricted funding for the original activity.

03 • Program lead: The new activity supports our mission. Doesn't that make the change acceptable within the grant?

04 • Grants manager: Mission fit matters, but it doesn't establish permission to change a funded deliverable or spending category.

05 • Program lead: Then which documents should we review before presenting the transfer as an available option?

06 • Grants manager: The award terms and approved budget, along with any applicable change process or donor correspondence.

07 • Program lead: Could you confirm whether the proposal requires permission, rather than assuming approval is only an administrative formality?

08 • Grants manager: Yes. I'll identify the relevant condition or flag the question for the responsible reviewer.

09 • Program lead: I'll keep the transfer as a proposal and avoid instructing finance to move the money yet.

10 • Grants manager: Good. We'll clarify the restriction and approval path before making a commitment to the new activity.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A deliverable or an illustrative example?

Separate fictional case: a draft grant proposal mentions six neighborhood sessions in one section and describes sessions as illustrative elsewhere; the application has not been submitted.

01 • Proposal coordinator: The draft mentions six sessions, but another section calls them illustrative. Which statement reflects our intended deliverable?

02 • Program director: We haven't settled that distinction. I don't want the proposal to promise a fixed number accidentally.

03 • Proposal coordinator: Could you clarify whether six is our planned commitment or simply an example of possible activity?

04 • Program director: I need to confirm delivery capacity first. At present, neither wording should be treated as an approved commitment.

05 • Proposal coordinator: Then I'll mark the inconsistency and ask the delivery team for the information needed to decide.

06 • Program director: Please also check how the proposed activity connects to the donor's stated purpose and our mission.

07 • Proposal coordinator: Yes. Mission fit and deliverable scope need separate clarification; one doesn't answer the other.

08 • Program director: Can we keep drafting the remaining sections without submitting this ambiguous version?

09 • Proposal coordinator: Certainly. I'll identify this as an open approval question before the application is finalized.

10 • Program director: I'll bring a confirmed scope decision after reviewing capacity, so the final proposal says what we actually intend.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Unspent does not necessarily mean unrestricted

Separate fictional case: a project has an unspent travel budget and proposes buying equipment; no review of the award's budget-change conditions has occurred.

01 • Project coordinator: The travel line has money left. Could we use it to buy equipment for the same project?

02 • Finance partner: Possibly, but unspent money isn't necessarily unrestricted. We need to check the award's budget-change conditions.

03 • Project coordinator: Could you clarify whether the restriction concerns the project purpose, the budget category, or both?

04 • Finance partner: That's what the documents need to establish. I don't want to infer permission from the remaining balance.

05 • Project coordinator: Should I get an equipment quote now, or would that imply we've approved the purchase?

06 • Finance partner: A clearly labeled planning quote can inform discussion, but it must not become an order or commitment.

07 • Project coordinator: Understood. I'll explain the proposed use and keep any purchasing step conditional on the review.

08 • Finance partner: Please bring the approved budget and award reference so the restriction question is specific.

09 • Project coordinator: I'll do that and avoid telling the team that unused travel funding is automatically available.

10 • Finance partner: Then we can clarify the authorized route without inventing a donor permission or a spending rule.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

Scenario 2 | A donor offers equipment instead of cash

A fictional donor offers laptops rather than the cash requested for facilitator time. The program needs trained facilitators, and ownership, support, and any donation conditions are unknown. Hold a clarification call before accepting the offer.

Role A: You are the program lead. Explain the original need and ask how the proposed donation supports it.

Role B: You are the grants coordinator. Identify the conditions and practical responsibilities that need clarification.

Possible opening: Could we clarify the laptop donation's conditions before deciding whether it fits the program's actual need?

Success checks

- Distinguish stated donation value from mission fit.
- Ask about ownership, support, and restrictions without inventing answers.
- Agree what must be clarified before acceptance.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to accept immediately because the offer has a high stated value.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Improvement during the program is not proof of attribution

The lesson's participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

01 • Evaluation manager: Participant outcomes improved during the program. We can report that observation, but attribution remains uncertain.

02 • Program director: Could you explain why we can't simply say the program caused the improvement?

03 • Evaluation manager: We haven't examined a comparison group or alternative explanations, so the observed change doesn't isolate our contribution.

04 • Program director: The baseline helps show a change over time, but it doesn't answer the cause question by itself.

05 • Evaluation manager: Exactly. An indicator describes a measured result; a causal claim needs additional support.

06 • Program director: I don't want our update to sound as if the improvement is meaningless, though.

07 • Evaluation manager: It isn't meaningless. State the positive observation and the limitation together, without erasing either.

08 • Program director: I'll say outcomes improved among participants while noting that we haven't established how much change the program caused.

09 • Evaluation manager: Good. Our learning agenda can identify which alternative explanations and follow-up questions deserve attention.

10 • Program director: Let's present those next questions as learning work, not as findings we already have.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The follow-up respondents differ from the baseline group

Separate fictional case: eighty people completed a baseline survey, but only forty completed follow-up; average scores rose among follow-up respondents, and nonrespondents are unexamined.

01 • Monitoring officer: Eighty people completed baseline, but only forty responded at follow-up. The reported improvement concerns those respondents.

02 • Program lead: Can we describe the average rise as improvement across the original eighty participants?

03 • Monitoring officer: Not without more evidence. We don't know the outcomes of those who didn't complete follow-up.

04 • Program lead: Could nonresponse be related to how people experienced the program, or is that only a possibility?

05 • Monitoring officer: It's a possibility worth examining, not an established explanation for the missing data.

06 • Program lead: Then the indicator report needs both respondent counts and a clear statement about the missing outcomes.

07 • Monitoring officer: Yes. We should also check whether the baseline comparison uses the same people where that is appropriate.

08 • Program lead: I'll avoid claiming universal improvement or assuming nonrespondents had the same experience as respondents.

09 • Monitoring officer: Good. The learning agenda can include a proportionate review of follow-up participation and measurement limits.

10 • Program lead: Let's report the observed change precisely and keep the broader participant outcome question open.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A changed indicator breaks the comparison

Separate fictional case: last quarter's participation indicator counted any attendance; this quarter it counts attendance at three sessions. The dashboard shows a decline.

01 • Learning lead: The participation indicator changed from any attendance to three sessions. The quarterly figures are not directly comparable.

02 • Program coordinator: The dashboard looks like participation fell. Could the new definition explain some of that difference?

03 • Learning lead: It could, but we need a consistent calculation to distinguish definition effects from actual participation changes.

04 • Program coordinator: So we shouldn't attribute the apparent decline to weaker outreach before checking the measurement basis.

05 • Learning lead: Correct. First identify the definition change and avoid presenting it as an observed behavioral decline.

06 • Program coordinator: Can we recalculate both periods using one definition if the underlying attendance records support it?

07 • Learning lead: Yes. Check the available records first, and report any limits rather than filling gaps with assumptions.

08 • Program coordinator: I'll explain the discontinuity in the dashboard and keep our outreach explanation provisional.

09 • Learning lead: Good. Baseline consistency is essential if we want the indicator to support a meaningful comparison.

10 • Program coordinator: I'll bring the comparable figures or a clear account of why they cannot yet be produced.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

Scenario 2 | An unusually positive interview sample

A fictional program's success stories come from five participants selected by facilitators for strong progress. The broader participant group has not been interviewed. Discuss what the stories can illustrate and what they cannot establish.

Role A: You are the evaluation officer. Explain the limited sample and avoid generalizing its experience.

Role B: You are the fundraising manager. Ask whether the interviews demonstrate typical outcomes.

Possible opening: These interviews illustrate five selected experiences, not the typical outcome across the whole program.

Success checks

- Identify the selection method and sample limit.
- Separate illustration from a representative outcome claim.
- Agree a broader learning question without inventing an average result.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to describe the five stories as proof that the program works for everyone.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The visit date changed, but the transport did not

The lesson's implementing partner changed a field-visit date; the community contact has not been informed and transport remains booked for the original date.

01 • Field coordinator: The visit date changed, but the community contact hasn't been told and transport still reflects the original plan.

02 • Partner liaison: We need a clear handoff. Which communication will you own, and what should I confirm?

03 • Field coordinator: I'll coordinate the transport review. Can you accept responsibility for contacting the community through the agreed channel?

04 • Partner liaison: Yes. I'll explain the proposed change and check their availability rather than assume the new date works.

05 • Field coordinator: Thank you. The partner's changed plan does not establish community agreement or a revised transport booking.

06 • Partner liaison: Understood. I'll report the contact's response before we describe the field visit as rescheduled and confirmed.

07 • Field coordinator: I'll check transport options and any contingency without authorizing an unreviewed change beyond my role.

08 • Partner liaison: Let's also avoid leaving people expecting us on the original date; that could damage community trust.

09 • Field coordinator: Agreed. Please repeat the pending actions when briefing the implementing partner.

10 • Partner liaison: I confirm community availability; you review transport. We exchange confirmations before presenting the revised visit as settled.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A delivery handover with an unreadable count

Separate fictional case: a partner's delivery sheet is legible except for the quantity of teaching kits; the receiving coordinator has not counted the kits yet.

01 • Logistics officer: The teaching-kit quantity is unreadable on the delivery sheet, and the receiving count is still pending.

02 • Partner coordinator: Can I acknowledge the handover as complete if I can confirm that the vehicle arrived?

03 • Logistics officer: You can acknowledge arrival, but not a verified quantity. Those are different parts of the handover.

04 • Partner coordinator: I'll arrange the receiving count through our normal process and compare it with a clear source record.

05 • Logistics officer: I'll request a readable dispatch copy from the sending team so you have the intended quantity.

06 • Partner coordinator: Should I copy the most likely number into the sheet to avoid delaying our field visit?

07 • Logistics officer: No. Keep the quantity unresolved until it is checked; a guessed count could create further confusion.

08 • Partner coordinator: Understood. My responsibility is the receiving count, and yours is obtaining the readable dispatch record.

09 • Logistics officer: Correct. We'll reconcile any difference and avoid calling the transfer fully verified before that happens.

10 • Partner coordinator: I'll confirm the result and flag any remaining mismatch directly to you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An interpreter request needs an acknowledged owner

Separate fictional case: a planned community consultation requires an interpreter, but neither the nonprofit nor its implementing partner has confirmed a booking.

01 • Community engagement lead: The consultation needs an interpreter, but both teams show the booking as pending.

02 • Partner operations coordinator: We thought your team would arrange it. Can we assign responsibility clearly before confirming the visit details?

03 • Community engagement lead: Yes. Can your operations team check availability through the agreed booking process and report the result?

04 • Partner operations coordinator: I can accept that coordination task, but I can't promise an interpreter until the booking is confirmed.

05 • Community engagement lead: Understood. I'll keep the community-facing plan conditional and explain the unresolved access arrangement internally.

06 • Partner operations coordinator: If availability doesn't match the planned visit, who will discuss a contingency with the community contact?

07 • Community engagement lead: I'll own that discussion. We should not substitute another arrangement without checking whether it meets their needs.

08 • Partner operations coordinator: Then I'll report confirmed availability or the specific gap, rather than mark the request handled after one email.

09 • Community engagement lead: Exactly. A requested booking is not an accepted booking, and accessibility affects meaningful participation.

10 • Partner operations coordinator: I'll confirm ownership now and return the actual booking status before the visit is finalized.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Field Operations and Partner Coordination

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

Scenario 2 | A community contact asks for a different meeting place

For a fictional field visit, the community contact proposes moving from the school to the library. The implementing partner has not checked library availability, and the transport driver still has the school address. Agree a bounded coordination handoff.

Role A: You are the community liaison. Confirm that the venue change is a request, not an agreed booking.

Role B: You are the partner operations lead. Accept the availability check and arrange the transport update only after confirmation.

Possible opening: The library is the community contact's proposed venue, but its availability has not been confirmed.

Success checks

- Distinguish requested and confirmed venue status.
- Assign venue checking and transport communication explicitly.
- Read back the dependency before finalizing visit instructions.

Add a complication: A team member wants to tell everyone the library is booked because it was requested.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Route a concern without unnecessary circulation

In the lesson's safeguarding case, a manager discusses routing a volunteer's concern with the safeguarding focal point; no identifying details are included in this training exchange.

01 • Program manager: A volunteer raised a safeguarding concern. Could you help me use our established reporting process without unnecessary circulation?

02 • Safeguarding focal point: Yes. Please use the designated reporting channel and keep identifying details out of this general conversation.

03 • Program manager: Should I question other volunteers first so the incident report contains a more complete explanation?

04 • Safeguarding focal point: Don't start an informal investigation. Follow the reporting process and distinguish what was reported from what you observed.

05 • Program manager: Understood. I want to handle the information carefully without promising confidentiality beyond what our process allows.

06 • Safeguarding focal point: Exactly. Use the approved explanation of confidentiality and the survivor-centered approach specified by our organization.

07 • Program manager: Could you confirm the secure route now, so I don't delay by guessing where the concern belongs?

08 • Safeguarding focal point: I'll direct you to the established channel and confirm how the authorized team acknowledges receipt.

09 • Program manager: I'll provide the relevant information there and avoid adding assumptions about what happened.

10 • Safeguarding focal point: Good. Keep the next action focused on appropriate reporting, not deciding the allegation yourself.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A concern sent to a shared inbox

Separate fictional case: a fictional nonprofit receives a safeguarding message in a general project inbox; the coordinator asks its designated focal point for the approved transfer route.

01 • Project coordinator: A safeguarding message reached our shared inbox. Please confirm its approved transfer route.

02 • Safeguarding focal point: Use our established handling process. Don't forward it to the whole project team to find an available reviewer.

03 • Project coordinator: I won't repeat the identifying details here. Should I create my own summary and discard the original?

04 • Safeguarding focal point: No. Follow the organization's instructions for preserving and routing the original information; don't improvise deletion or retention.

05 • Project coordinator: Could you help me identify who acknowledges receipt, so I can confirm the concern hasn't been lost?

06 • Safeguarding focal point: Yes. I'll connect you with the designated reporting route and its acknowledgment process.

07 • Project coordinator: If a colleague asks what the message says, I'll explain that access is limited to the appropriate handling process.

08 • Safeguarding focal point: Good. Confidentiality means careful information handling, not a promise that nobody else will ever need to know.

09 • Project coordinator: I'll complete the authorized transfer and report the routing status without discussing the substance in this inbox.

10 • Safeguarding focal point: That keeps the request actionable and protects the information from unnecessary circulation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An update request without case details

Separate fictional case: a manager knows a safeguarding concern was submitted through the approved channel but has no acknowledgment reference; they ask only about receipt, not findings.

01 • Volunteer manager: Could you confirm receipt of the concern submitted through our reporting channel? I don't have an acknowledgment reference.

02 • Safeguarding coordinator: I can check the routing status through the authorized process. Please don't repeat the case details here.

03 • Volunteer manager: Thank you. I'm not asking for investigative findings, only whether the report reached the responsible team.

04 • Safeguarding coordinator: That distinction matters. An acknowledgment confirms receipt, not a conclusion or permission to share information more widely.

05 • Volunteer manager: A team leader wants an update for the whole group. Should I summarize the allegation for them?

06 • Safeguarding coordinator: Use our established communication guidance instead. Don't assume a general team update needs the allegation's details.

07 • Volunteer manager: Understood. Could you tell me which approved wording applies when colleagues ask about the reporting status?

08 • Safeguarding coordinator: I'll obtain that guidance and confirm what can appropriately be communicated within your role.

09 • Volunteer manager: I'll wait for the authorized wording and avoid promising a particular investigation outcome or completion date.

10 • Safeguarding coordinator: Good. I'll focus this follow-up on receipt and the appropriate communication route.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

Scenario 2 | A volunteer asks for absolute secrecy

In a fictional training exercise, a volunteer asks a manager to promise absolute secrecy before sharing a safeguarding concern. The organization has a designated reporting process, but its confidentiality explanation must be consulted. Practice requesting the approved explanation without eliciting case details.

Role A: You are the manager. Ask the safeguarding focal point how to explain information handling accurately.

Role B: You are the focal point. Direct the manager to the established process and avoid giving a blanket secrecy promise.

Possible opening: Could you help me explain our reporting process accurately before I make any promise about confidentiality?

Success checks

- Use respectful language without promising absolute secrecy.
- Keep identifying details out of the practice exchange.
- Agree the approved reporting and confidentiality explanation as the next step.

Add a complication: The manager fears that admitting limits will sound uncaring.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Enthusiasm beyond the agreed role

Separate fictional case aligned with the lesson: a reception volunteer trained to book appointments offers to conduct eligibility interviews alone; those interviews belong to the trained program team.

01 • Volunteer supervisor: You offered to conduct eligibility interviews alone, but your agreed reception role covers appointment booking.

02 • Reception volunteer: I wanted to help with the queue. I thought listening to an interview meant I could conduct one.

03 • Volunteer supervisor: Observing helps you learn, but it does not establish the training or authorization this task requires.

04 • Reception volunteer: I see. I could give visitors an inaccurate impression that I am making an official assessment.

05 • Volunteer supervisor: Exactly. Please continue booking appointments and refer eligibility questions to the trained program team.

06 • Reception volunteer: Can I still ask about developing my volunteer role without taking on those interviews now?

07 • Volunteer supervisor: Certainly. We can discuss appropriate training and supervision with the program lead, without promising a role change.

08 • Reception volunteer: For this shift, I will manage bookings and ask the program team to handle interview requests.

09 • Volunteer supervisor: Good. If the queue grows, tell me so we can coordinate support within the agreed arrangements.

10 • Reception volunteer: I will. I will not conduct interviews independently, and I will raise the queue issue with you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A helpful answer that went beyond training

Separate fictional case: a reception volunteer answered a visitor's eligibility question despite being trained only to explain appointment booking; no eligibility decision is established.

01 • Volunteer supervisor: You told the visitor they were eligible, although your current role covers appointment booking, not eligibility assessment.

02 • Reception volunteer: I recognized one condition from the leaflet and assumed that was enough. I should have checked.

03 • Volunteer supervisor: That answer may create an expectation of approval. The program team needs to assess the relevant information.

04 • Reception volunteer: Should I contact the visitor myself and say they are not eligible instead?

05 • Volunteer supervisor: No. That would make another unsupported decision. I will arrange an appropriate correction with the program team.

06 • Reception volunteer: Understood. What should I say when another visitor asks whether meeting one condition guarantees approval?

07 • Volunteer supervisor: Explain that the authorized team assesses eligibility, and offer to help with the appointment process.

08 • Reception volunteer: I can say, I can help you book, but the program team must answer the eligibility question.

09 • Volunteer supervisor: Exactly. Let's practice two more examples together before you return to the reception desk.

10 • Reception volunteer: Yes. I will keep my answers within booking and ask for support when a question goes beyond it.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A shift handover missing the unresolved request

Separate fictional case: a volunteer's handover omitted an unresolved accessible-appointment request, so the receiving coordinator could not follow up without asking the visitor again.

01 • Shift supervisor: Your handover listed completed tasks but omitted the accessible-appointment request the next coordinator needed.

02 • Reception volunteer: I thought the handover covered only finished work. I did not realize pending requests belonged there too.

03 • Shift supervisor: Without that action, the coordinator had to ask the visitor to explain the request again.

04 • Reception volunteer: I understand the effect. Should I include every detail from the visitor's conversation next time?

05 • Shift supervisor: No. Use the approved record and share only what the receiving role needs to take the next action.

06 • Reception volunteer: Then I should identify the outstanding appointment request and ask who will accept the follow-up.

07 • Shift supervisor: Exactly. End the handover with a spoken check of pending actions and the person responsible.

08 • Reception volunteer: For my next shift change, I will ask the coordinator to confirm the outstanding action before I leave.

09 • Shift supervisor: Good. I will observe that handover and help if the responsibility or information is unclear.

10 • Reception volunteer: Thank you. I will distinguish completed work from requests still needing attention and confirm the receiving owner.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Volunteer Management and Training

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

Scenario 2 | A volunteer changes the appointment order

A fictional reception volunteer rearranged appointment order to help a late arrival without consulting the supervisor. Two people then received conflicting instructions. The supervisor can consult the applicable scheduling process. Give feedback directly to the volunteer and agree what they will do next time.

Role A: You are the supervisor. Describe the observed change and its effect, then ask the volunteer to consult before changing appointment order.

Role B: You are the reception volunteer. Explain your intention, respond to the conflicting instructions, and agree a specific consultation step without making another unauthorized change.

Possible opening: Changing the appointment order without checking created conflicting instructions for two visitors.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the intention without dismissing the observed effect.
- Explain and respond to the role boundary directly.
- Have the volunteer state a specific consultation step for the next similar situation.

Add a complication: The volunteer argues that helping the late arrival justified the change, even though the other visitors were affected.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A striking statistic without a source

The lesson's fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic with no source or date, and the campaign team wants to publish immediately.

01 • Campaign editor: The fundraising draft contains an alarming statistic, but its source and date are missing.

02 • Advocacy lead: It would give the campaign urgency. Can we keep it while someone looks for the reference?

03 • Campaign editor: We shouldn't publish it as established evidence before verification. Urgency doesn't establish accuracy or current relevance.

04 • Advocacy lead: Could we qualify it with reportedly rather than delay the whole message?

05 • Campaign editor: That word doesn't supply a source. We need to verify the claim or use wording supported by known information.

06 • Advocacy lead: Agreed. We should also consider whether the language respects the dignity of the people described.

07 • Campaign editor: Yes. An unsupported dramatic claim can misrepresent both their circumstances and our evidence.

08 • Advocacy lead: I'll ask the draft owner for the original source, date, and relevant population before using the figure.

09 • Campaign editor: I'll keep the statistic out of the publish-ready version until the appropriate review is complete.

10 • Advocacy lead: Then we can discuss an accurate campaign message without treating an unverified number as essential.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A participant quotation with an uncertain permission scope

Separate fictional case: a nonprofit has a participant quotation from an internal learning interview; permission for a public advocacy campaign has not been confirmed.

01 • Advocacy producer: This interview quotation is powerful, but we haven't confirmed permission to use it in the public campaign.

02 • Program communications lead: The participant agreed to the interview. Doesn't that establish permission to publish their words more widely?

03 • Advocacy producer: Not from the information we have. The interview agreement and public-use permission need to be checked.

04 • Program communications lead: Then I shouldn't describe the quotation as cleared just because it appears in our internal report.

05 • Advocacy producer: Correct. We also need to preserve context and dignity, rather than select wording only for emotional effect.

06 • Program communications lead: Could we anonymize it and assume that removes the permission question?

07 • Advocacy producer: No. Anonymization doesn't establish the scope of the original agreement. Use the organization's review process.

08 • Program communications lead: I'll ask the responsible colleague to verify permission and context without contacting the participant outside that process.

09 • Advocacy producer: Good. Meanwhile, keep the quotation out of the approved campaign assets and identify the unresolved question.

10 • Program communications lead: I'll do that and avoid claiming the quotation represents every participant's experience.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A campaign photograph from another year

Separate fictional case: an advocacy draft pairs a current event appeal with a clearly dated photograph from three years earlier; the caption omits the date.

01 • Visual communications editor: The photograph is from three years ago, but the current-event appeal doesn't identify that date.

02 • Campaign manager: Could readers assume it shows the present event, even though the photograph itself is genuine?

03 • Visual communications editor: Yes. A real image can still create an unsupported impression when the context is missing.

04 • Campaign manager: Then our issue isn't proving the photograph is fake; it's accurately describing what it shows.

05 • Visual communications editor: Exactly. We need the known date and context visible, alongside the usual permissions and dignity review.

06 • Campaign manager: Would calling it illustrative be enough without explaining that it comes from a different period?

07 • Visual communications editor: Let's avoid relying on an ambiguous label. The caption should not encourage a current-event interpretation we cannot support.

08 • Campaign manager: I'll ask for a contextually accurate asset or a clear caption, rather than suggest the image documents today's conditions.

09 • Visual communications editor: Good. Keep the campaign's verified claims separate from what the older photograph can establish.

10 • Campaign manager: We'll review the revised pairing before publication so the appeal remains accurate as well as compelling.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

Scenario 2 | An advocacy headline turns correlation into cause

A fictional report finds that service use and school attendance rose during the same year. A campaign headline says the service caused the attendance increase. No causal analysis is supplied. Discuss a supported headline claim aloud.

Role A: You are the advocacy lead. Explain the known concurrent changes without claiming causation.

Role B: You are the campaign editor. Ask which source and scope should accompany the statement.

Possible opening: The report shows both measures rose, but it doesn't establish that our service caused the attendance increase.

Success checks

- Distinguish concurrent observations from a causal finding.
- Request the report's missing source and scope details before agreeing a final headline.
- Agree accurate spoken wording for the claim before publication review.

Add a complication: A campaign partner says the causal headline will attract more attention.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Restricted balances are not automatically available reserves

The lesson's board considers reserves or reduced program activity during a funding gap; some funds are restricted and no detailed forecast is supplied.

01 • Board finance chair: We need to compare using reserves with reducing program activity during the funding gap.

02 • Executive director: The bank balance looks sufficient, but some funds are restricted. We shouldn't treat all cash as available reserves.

03 • Board finance chair: Agreed. Can we compare both scenarios over the same period and separate usable funds from restricted balances?

04 • Executive director: Yes. Using available reserves may preserve activity temporarily, while reducing activity changes delivery and may conserve cash.

05 • Board finance chair: Neither option should be presented as automatically safer without the cash forecast and program implications.

06 • Executive director: Correct. We also need to identify which assumptions drive the cash runway in each scenario.

07 • Board finance chair: Could the forecast include expected donations as guaranteed receipts to make the gap look manageable?

08 • Executive director: No. Unconfirmed funding should remain an assumption, not a certainty in the base figures.

09 • Board finance chair: I'll ask for a consistent comparison and the relevant restrictions before the board makes its decision.

10 • Executive director: I'll bring the program tradeoffs and forecast uncertainties, keeping this as a governance discussion rather than a predetermined answer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A bridge donation that has not been pledged

Separate fictional case: a nonprofit compares maintaining four weekly sessions with reducing to two; a possible donor contribution is under discussion but not pledged.

01 • Executive director: We can model four weekly sessions or two, but the possible donor contribution is not pledged.

02 • Board treasurer: Then neither scenario should count that contribution as a confirmed source of cash.

03 • Executive director: Agreed. The reduced schedule lowers activity, while maintaining four sessions preserves current access for now.

04 • Board treasurer: What else needs comparison besides the immediate cash use in each scenario?

05 • Executive director: Participant continuity, staffing implications, and whether any funding restrictions affect the planned spending.

06 • Board treasurer: Could we calculate cash runway only for the reduced schedule because that option appears more cautious?

07 • Executive director: We should calculate both using the same period and assumptions, so the board can see the actual tradeoff.

08 • Board treasurer: Yes. And any donor-funded variant should be labeled conditional on a contribution that isn't yet committed.

09 • Executive director: I'll present the two operating scenarios and keep potential funding separate from confirmed resources.

10 • Board treasurer: That gives board governance a clearer basis without pretending the preferred option has no service consequences.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A reserve-funded restart or a gradual reopening

Separate fictional case: a nonprofit considers restarting all three community groups together or reopening one first; restart costs and facilitator availability are not yet confirmed.

01 • Board program chair: Restarting all three groups restores activity sooner, whereas reopening one first creates a smaller initial commitment.

02 • Operations director: That's the broad distinction, but restart costs and facilitator availability still need confirmation for both scenarios.

03 • Board program chair: Could a smaller restart also postpone access for participants in the other two groups?

04 • Operations director: Yes, that is a program tradeoff to discuss, not something the reserve calculation captures by itself.

05 • Board program chair: Then the comparison should include service access alongside cash use and operational readiness.

06 • Operations director: Agreed. We shouldn't describe either option as funded or staffed until the relevant information is verified.

07 • Board program chair: What common time horizon would let the board compare the reserve effect fairly?

08 • Operations director: Let's agree that with finance and apply it to both options rather than select whichever period favors one.

09 • Board program chair: I'll request the consistent forecast and ask the program team to explain the access implications.

10 • Operations director: I'll obtain readiness information so the board sees both the benefits and the limitations of each restart plan.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Board Reporting and Sustainability

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Second round: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for scenario 1: The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

Scenario 2 | A lease extension during a funding gap

A fictional nonprofit can discuss a six-month office extension or moving to shared space. The shared-space fee is lower, but moving costs and suitability for confidential appointments are unassessed. Compare the options over six months for a board discussion.

Role A: You are the operations director. Identify known fees and missing operational costs.

Role B: You are the board finance chair. Ask about reserve use and the effect on service delivery.

Possible opening: The shared-space fee is lower, but we haven't included moving costs or checked whether appointments can be held appropriately.

Success checks

- Use the same six-month comparison period.
- Distinguish a lower fee from verified total savings.
- State service and cash tradeoffs and request the missing evidence.

Add a complication: A board member calls the fee difference a confirmed saving.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Nonprofit and NGO English

Professional audience: nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Dialogue 01: Theory of change

Original fictional setting: A program team connects activities to intended outcomes.

Professional roles: Program manager / Evaluation lead

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Program manager: Our plan lists workshops, but it doesn't explain how they lead to the outcome we promise.

Evaluation lead: Map the intended change, the assumptions, and the evidence connecting each step.

Program manager: Attendance would measure delivery, not whether participants can apply the skill.

Evaluation lead: Exactly. We need suitable outcome measures and a feasible way to collect them.

Program manager: I'll revise the program logic and identify assumptions we need to test.

Evaluation lead: I'll help align the evaluation questions with what the program can reasonably demonstrate.

Vocabulary in this exchange: outcome: A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Program manager: I'll revise the program logic and identify assumptions we need to test.

Evaluation lead: I'll help align the evaluation questions with what the program can reasonably demonstrate.

Vocabulary in this exchange: outcome: A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

END REFERENCE**TASK:** Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level